



HS202 – Project Report

Group – 8

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ABSTRACT:

In college campuses, the process of reporting and recovering lost items is often unorganized and inefficient. Students usually depend on informal channels such as WhatsApp groups and email notices, which often create cluttered information, lack proper categorization, and make searching for relevant posts difficult. As a result, many lost items remain unclaimed even when they are reported.

To address this issue, we developed **FOUND-IT**, a web-based platform designed for students of Indian Institute of Technology Ropar that provides a centralized system to report, search, and manage lost and found items. The platform includes features such as OTP-based user authentication, category-based filtering, secure messaging, and an AI-powered image matching system that suggests possible matches between lost and found items. It also enables users to connect through a secure claim and approval process.

The system improves efficiency, reduces search time, and increases the chances of recovering lost belongings. In addition, a karma-based incentive system encourages users to actively participate by reporting found items and helping others. Overall, FOUND-IT enhances coordination within the campus community and provides a scalable solution that can be extended to other educational institutions and public spaces.

Introduction:

In large academic campuses, students frequently misplace personal belongings such as ID cards, electronic devices, and daily-use items. The current methods used to report and recover these items are mainly WhatsApp groups, Telegram channels, and email bulletins which are unstructured and inefficient. These platforms often lead to information overload, lack of categorization, and difficulty in searching, resulting in many items remaining unclaimed.

With the growing campus population and activities at institutions like Indian Institute of Technology Ropar, there is a clear need for a more organized and efficient system. A centralized platform can simplify reporting, improve searchability, and ensure better communication between users.

To address this issue, we developed **FOUND-IT**, a web-based lost and found system that allows users to report, search, and claim items through a structured interface. With features such as secure authentication, category-based filtering, and AI-powered image matching, the system enhances the efficiency of item recovery and promotes better coordination within the campus community.

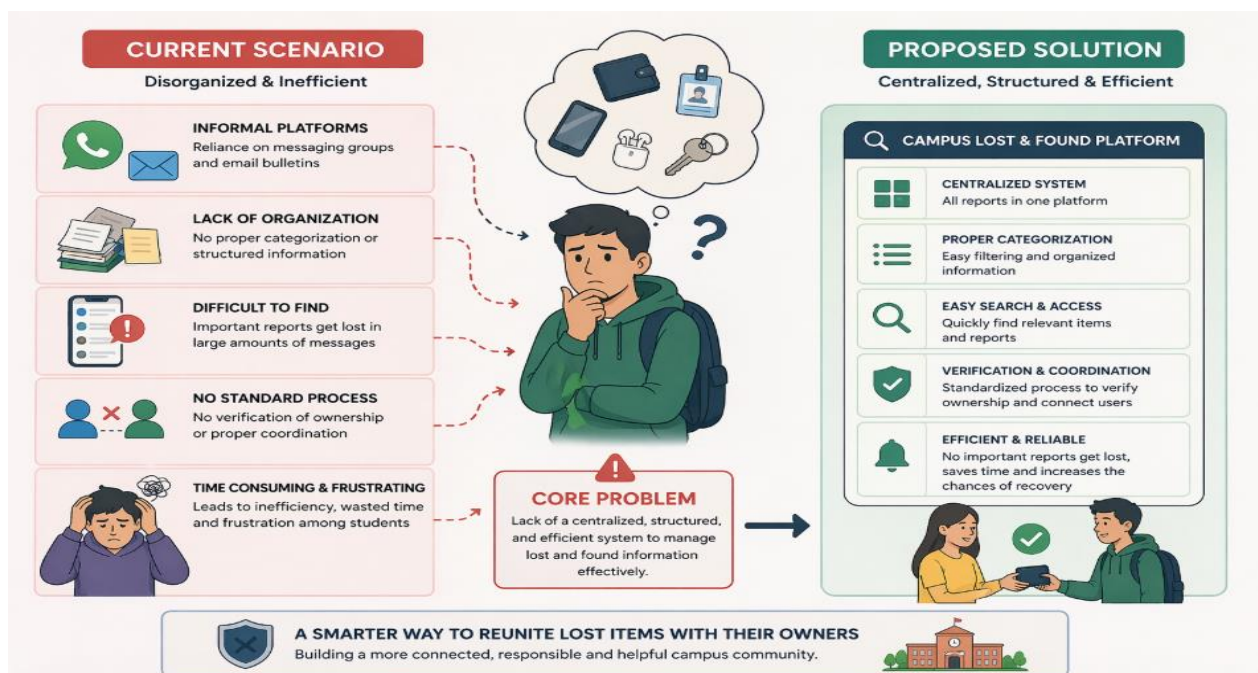


Problem Statement:

In campus environments, students frequently lose personal belongings such as ID cards, electronic devices, and daily-use items. The existing methods for reporting and recovering these items rely heavily on informal platforms like messaging groups and email bulletins, which are not designed for structured information management. These systems lack proper organization, categorization, and efficient search mechanisms, making it difficult for users to locate relevant information.

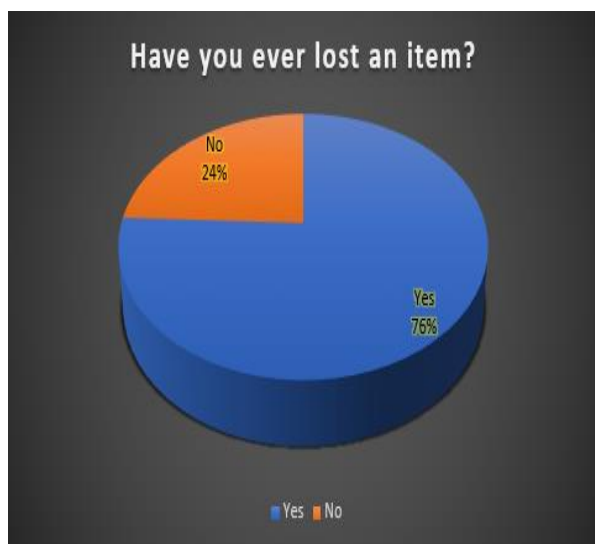
Additionally, the absence of a standardized process for verifying ownership and coordinating between users further reduces the chances of successful item recovery. As the volume of communication increases, important reports are often overlooked or lost within large amounts of unrelated content. This leads to inefficiency, wasted time, and frustration among students.

Hence, the core problem lies in the lack of a centralized, structured, and efficient system that can manage lost and found information effectively while ensuring ease of access, reliability, and user coordination.

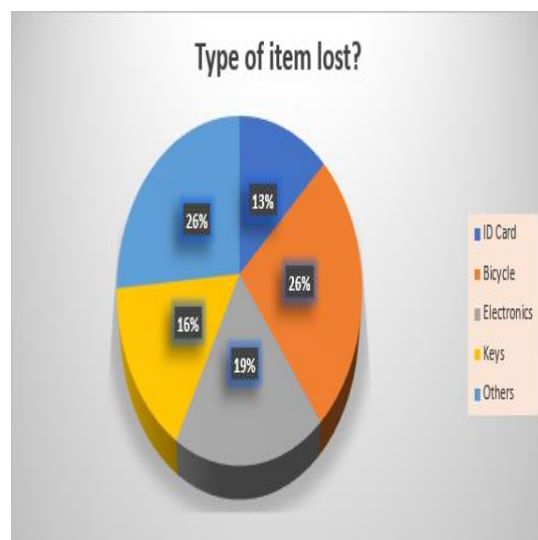


Survey Analysis & Results:

A survey was conducted among students to understand the common challenges in managing lost and found items on campus. The results show that 76% of respondents have lost an item at least once, while only 24% reported never losing any belongings. Among the lost items, bicycles and other miscellaneous items were the most common (26% each), followed by electronics (19%), keys (16%), and ID cards (13%). These findings highlight the frequent occurrence of misplaced personal belongings and emphasize the need for a more organized and efficient lost and found management system on campus.



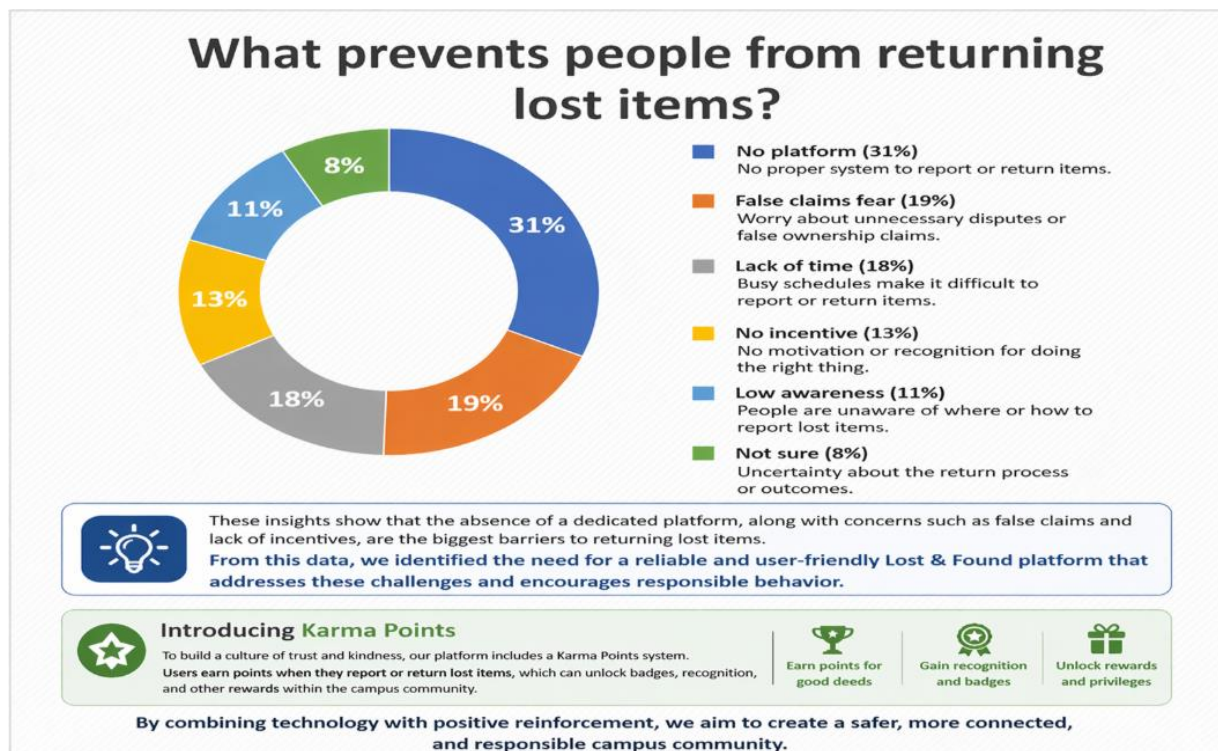
Percentage of people who lost items people lost



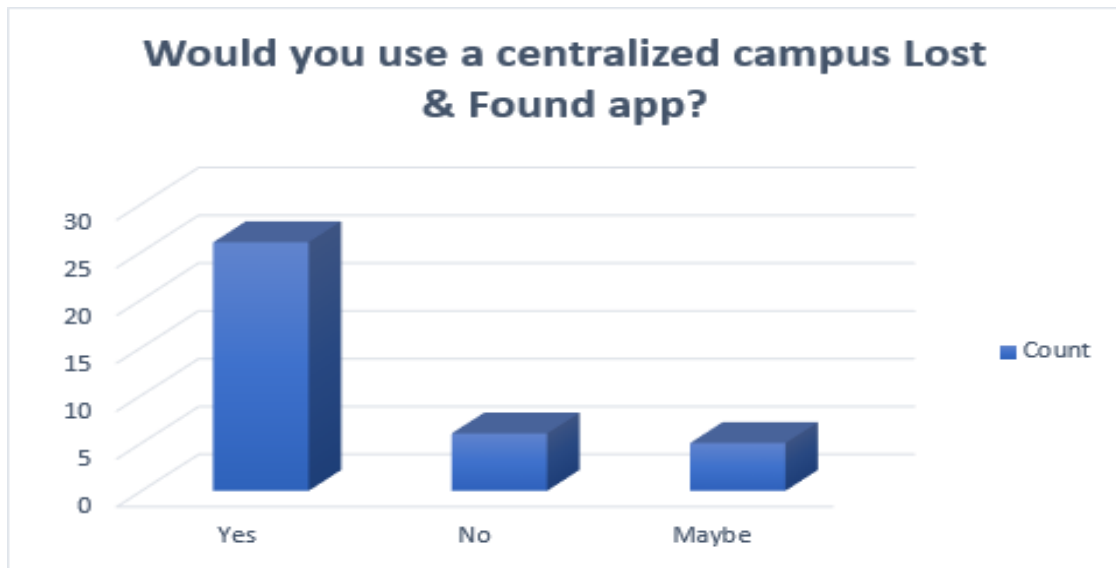
Types of items that

The survey results show that the biggest barrier preventing people from returning lost items is the absence of a proper platform, followed by concerns about false claims, lack of time, limited incentives, low awareness, and uncertainty about the return process. These findings clearly highlight the need for a dedicated and reliable Lost & Found platform that simplifies the process of reporting and returning lost items. Based on this insight, we developed the idea of creating a centralized

campus Lost & Found system with a Karma Points incentive feature. This system encourages students to act responsibly by rewarding users with points, recognition, and badges for reporting or returning lost items, helping to build a more trustworthy, supportive, and connected campus community.



The survey results show that a large majority of respondents would use a centralized campus Lost & Found app, with most participants selecting “Yes,” while only a small number chose “No” or “Maybe.” This indicates a strong demand for a dedicated and well-organized platform to manage lost and found items on campus. Respondents expressed the need for useful features such as category-based filtering, easy search options, and improved communication mechanisms. Many participants also showed interest in advanced features like image-based matching and instant notification systems, highlighting the potential value of a smart and efficient Lost & Found solution.



The survey results on satisfaction with the current Lost & Found system show mixed opinions among students. While some respondents rated the system as “Good,” a considerable number described it as “Bad” or only “Decent,” and very few considered it “Excellent.” This indicates that the existing methods are not fully meeting students’ needs. The findings highlight the limitations of the current system and demonstrate a strong demand for a more organized, efficient, and user-friendly platform to manage lost and found items on campus.



Objectives of the project:

1. Develop a Centralized Lost & Found System

To create a unified platform for reporting, searching, and managing lost and found items, replacing unstructured communication methods.

2. Enhance Search and Accessibility

To improve the efficiency of finding items through category-based filtering, organized listings, and a user-friendly interface.

3. Implement Intelligent Matching Mechanism

To integrate AI-based image comparison for identifying potential matches between lost and found items, increasing recovery accuracy.

4. Ensure Secure and Reliable User Interaction

To provide a structured claim and approval process that verifies ownership and enables safe communication between users.

5. Promote User Participation and Scalability

To encourage active involvement through incentive mechanisms and design a system that can be scaled to other institutions or larger environments.

Literature Review:

The management of lost and found items in campuses has traditionally relied on informal methods such as notice boards, word-of-mouth communication, and digital platforms like WhatsApp groups, Telegram channels, and email bulletins. Although these methods are widely used, they lack proper organization and structure. Information is often scattered, messages get buried in large volumes of content, and it becomes difficult for users to retrieve relevant details.

Several web-based systems and research studies have attempted to improve this process by introducing centralized platforms for reporting and searching lost items. These systems store item details in databases and allow users to browse or search records. However, most of them depend on manual input and basic keyword-based search, which limits efficiency and accuracy in identifying matching items.

Moreover, many existing solutions lack advanced features such as intelligent image-based matching and proper verification mechanisms. This increases the chances of incorrect matches and false claims. In addition, limited filtering options make it difficult for users to narrow down search results effectively.

Another major limitation is the lack of user engagement. Most systems do not provide incentives for users to report found items, leading to incomplete data and reduced participation. As a result, the overall effectiveness of these systems remains low.

These limitations highlight a clear gap in terms of organization, intelligent matching, user verification, and participation, indicating the need for a more efficient and structured approach to managing lost and found items.

Methodology:

The development of the system begins with analysing the limitations of existing lost and found methods, such as messaging groups and email bulletins. Based on this analysis, the system requirements are identified with a focus on improving organization, search efficiency, and user interaction.

The system is designed using a modular approach consisting of frontend, backend, database, and AI components. The user interface is kept simple and user-friendly, allowing easy navigation for reporting, searching, messaging, and claim-related activities. The database is structured to store item details, user information, images, messages, and match records in an organized manner for efficient retrieval.

The implementation is carried out using HTML, CSS, and JavaScript for the frontend, FastAPI with Python for backend operations, and MongoDB for data storage. Core functionalities such as user authentication, item reporting, category-based filtering, messaging, and claim processing are developed and integrated into the platform.

An AI-based image matching module is incorporated to compare uploaded images and suggest possible matches between lost and found items. Notification features are also included to alert users about new matches and important updates. Finally, the system is tested using various test cases to ensure accuracy, reliability, and smooth performance across all modules.

System Architecture:

The proposed system follows a modular client-server architecture that ensures smooth communication between all components. It is divided into four main layers: Frontend, Backend, Database, and AI Module, which work together to provide an efficient and user-friendly platform.

The frontend layer is developed using HTML, CSS, and JavaScript. It provides an interactive and responsive interface through which users can register, log in, report lost or found items, browse listings, and communicate with other users.

The backend layer is developed using Fast API and Python. It handles all server-side operations such as user authentication, request processing, item management, and application logic. It also acts as a connection between the frontend, database, and AI module.

The database layer uses MongoDB to store important data such as user information, item details, uploaded images, messages, and match records. It allows fast data storage, retrieval, and efficient management of records.

The AI module is used for image matching of lost and found items. It analyses uploaded images, compares visual features, and suggests possible matches based on similarity. This helps users identify items more accurately and quickly.

Overall, the system works in a structured manner where the user interacts with the frontend, requests are processed by the backend, data is managed through the database, and AI helps in finding matching items. This creates a smooth, reliable, and efficient workflow.

Technologies used:

The development of the system involves a combination of modern web technologies and tools to ensure efficiency, scalability, and a user-friendly experience.

1. HTML (Hyper Text Markup Language):

Used to create and structure the web pages, including forms, buttons, input fields, and page layouts.

2. CSS (Cascading Style Sheets):

Used for styling the website and designing an attractive, responsive, and user-friendly interface.

3. JavaScript:

Used to add dynamic behaviour, validate forms, manage user interactions, and connect the frontend with backend services.

4. Fast API (Python Framework):

Used for backend development to handle server-side logic, API creation, authentication, item management, and request processing efficiently.

5. Python:

Used as the main backend programming language and for implementing AI-based image matching features.

6. MongoDB:

A NoSQL database used to store user accounts, lost and found item details, chat messages, match results, and other application data efficiently.

7. Cloudinary:

Used for storing and managing uploaded item images securely on the cloud.

8. AI Image Matching Model (ResNet50 + Cosine Similarity):

Used to compare images of lost and found items by analysing visual features such as shape, color, and patterns. It identifies similar items and suggests possible matches automatically, making the recovery process faster and more accurate.

User Account SignUp/SignIn:

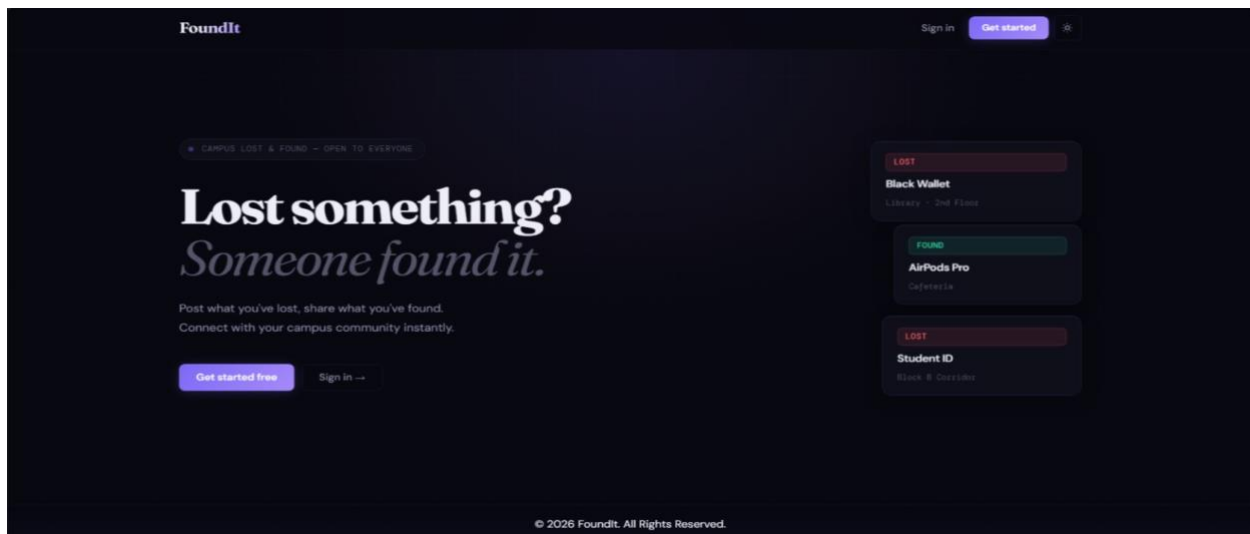
The system incorporates a secure and reliable user authentication mechanism to ensure that only authorized users can access the platform. This is essential to maintain data integrity, prevent misuse, and ensure that all interactions on the system are carried out by verified users within the institution.

The authentication system consists of three main functionalities: **user registration, login, and password recovery**. New users can register by providing their college email ID and setting a password. To verify authenticity, an OTP (One-Time Password) is sent to the provided email address. The account is activated only after successful OTP verification, ensuring that only genuine users are registered on the platform.

Registered users can log in using their email ID and password. The system validates the credentials through the backend before granting access. In case a user forgets their password, the **“Forgot Password”** feature allows them to reset it securely using OTP verification, maintaining account security without compromising accessibility.

Overall, this authentication system ensures secure access, protects user data, and builds trust by allowing only verified individuals to report, search,

and claim lost or found items on the platform.



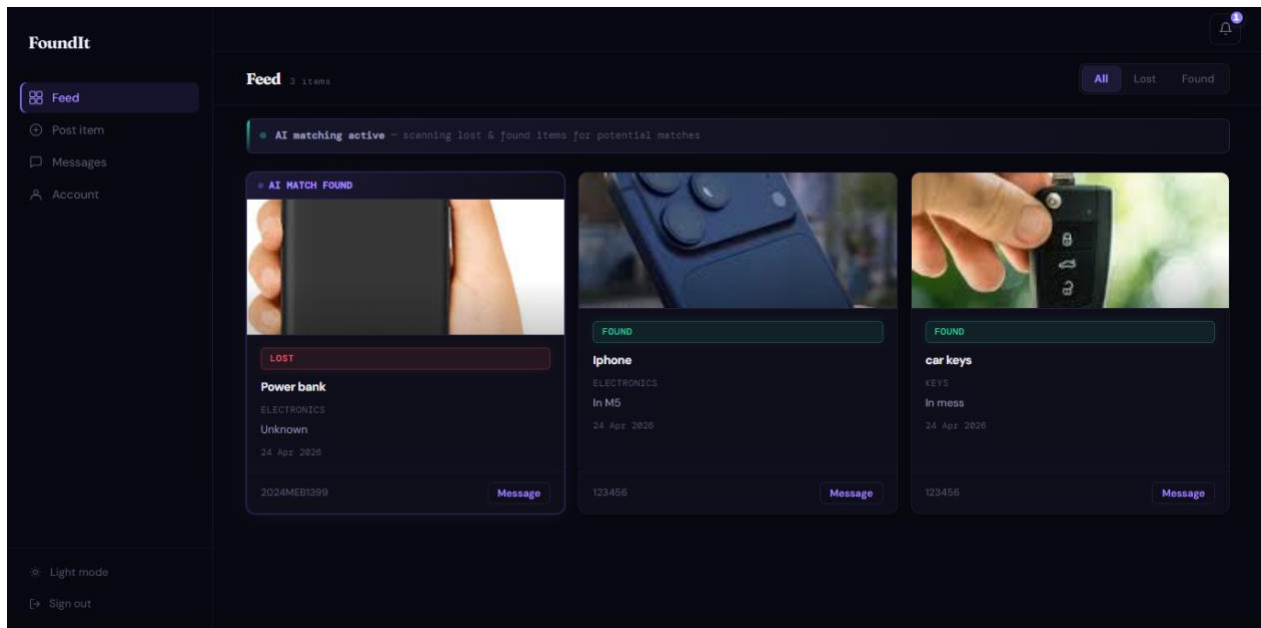
Dashboard & User Interface:

The dashboard and user interface of the system are designed to be simple, intuitive, and user-friendly, ensuring easy navigation and quick access to features. The design focuses on clarity and responsiveness, allowing users to perform actions efficiently.

After login, users are directed to the main dashboard, which provides two primary options: **“I Found Something”** and **“I Lost Something.”** Each section includes relevant actions such as reporting an item or searching/browsing listings, reducing complexity in navigation.

The interface includes well-structured components such as forms, buttons, and categorized listings. Users can report items through organized forms and browse items using filters and categories. Visual elements like cards, icons, and images enhance usability and make interaction smoother.

Overall, the interface provides a clean and organized experience, enabling users to efficiently report, search, and claim items within the system.



Report Lost Item Module:

The Report Lost Item module allows users to submit detailed information about items they have misplaced. This feature is designed to ensure that all relevant details are captured in a structured manner, making it easier to identify and match items later.

When a user selects this option, a form is displayed where they must enter details such as item name, category, description, and contact information. Additionally, users can upload an image of the lost item, which helps in better identification and improves the accuracy of matching.

Once the information is submitted, it is stored in the database and becomes visible in the lost items section. This data can then be accessed by other users and also used by the AI-based matching system to find possible matches with reported found items.

Overall, this module simplifies the process of reporting lost items by providing a clear, structured, and user-friendly interface, ensuring that important information is properly recorded and easily accessible.

The screenshot shows the 'Post item' form in the FoundIt application. The form is titled 'Post item' and has a 'Lost' button in the top right corner. The form is divided into several sections: a 'PHOTO' section with a placeholder for an image, a 'DETAILS' section with fields for 'ITEM NAME', 'CATEGORY', 'DATE', 'LOCATION', and 'DESCRIPTION', and a 'YOUR NAME' and 'PHONE' section. The 'ITEM NAME' field has a placeholder 'e.g. Black leather wallet'. The 'CATEGORY' field has a dropdown menu with 'Select category'. The 'DATE' field has a date picker showing '25-04-2026'. The 'LOCATION' field has a placeholder 'e.g. Library 2nd floor'. The 'DESCRIPTION' field has a placeholder 'Describe the item in detail...'. The 'YOUR NAME' field has a placeholder 'Full name' and the 'PHONE' field has a placeholder 'ID-digit number'. A 'Publish post' button is located at the bottom of the form. The left sidebar shows navigation options: 'Feed', 'Post item', 'Messages', and 'Account'. The bottom left corner has 'Light mode' and 'Sign out' options.

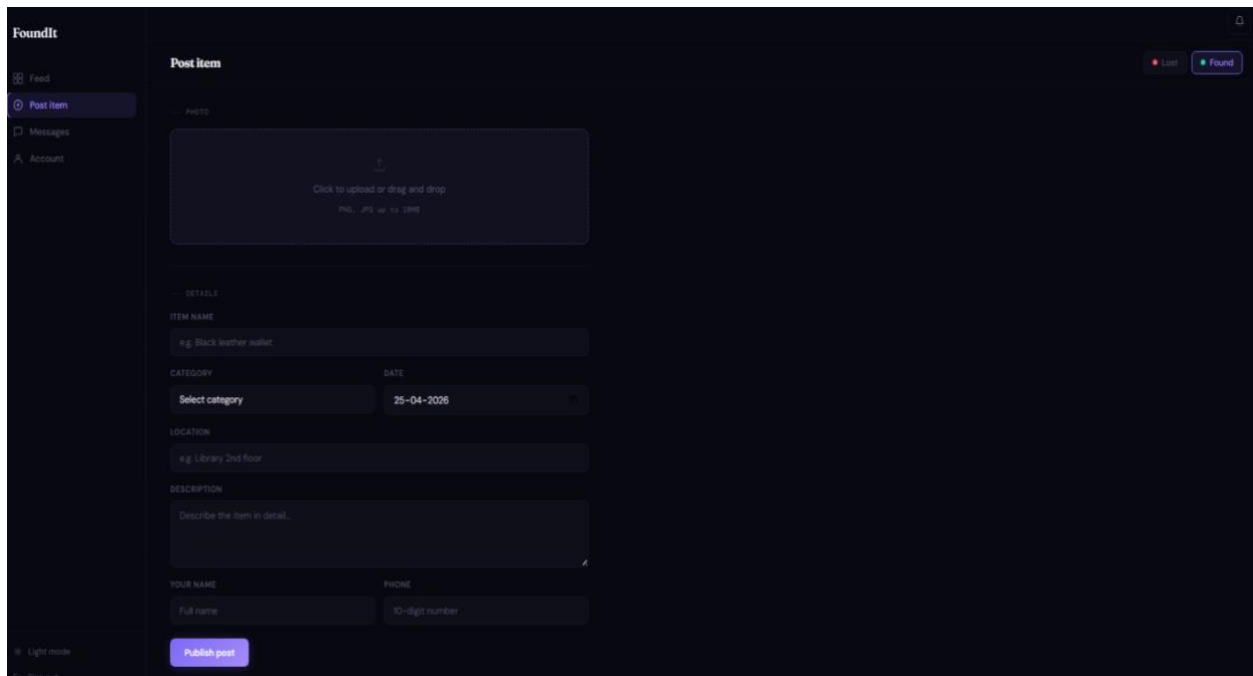
Report Found Item Module:

The Report Found Item module enables users to report items they have found on campus in a structured and organized manner. This feature plays a crucial role in increasing the chances of lost items being returned to their rightful owners.

When a user selects this option, a form is provided to enter details such as item name, category, description, and contact information. Users can also upload an image of the found item, which helps in accurate identification and improves the effectiveness of the matching process.

Once submitted, the information is stored in the database and displayed in the found items section, where other users can browse and search for their lost belongings. The data is also utilized by the AI-based image matching system to suggest potential matches.

Overall, this module encourages user participation and ensures that found items are properly recorded and made accessible, contributing to a more efficient and reliable lost and found system.

The screenshot shows a web application titled 'FoundIt' with a sidebar containing 'Feed', 'Post Item', 'Messages', and 'Account'. The 'Post Item' form is active, featuring a 'PHOTO' section with a placeholder for uploading a file. Below this is a 'DETAILS' section with input fields for 'ITEM NAME' (with a placeholder 'e.g. Black leather wallet'), 'CATEGORY' (a dropdown menu), 'DATE' (a date picker set to '25-04-2025'), 'LOCATION' (with a placeholder 'e.g. Library 2nd floor'), and 'DESCRIPTION' (with a placeholder 'Describe the item in detail'). At the bottom of the form are fields for 'YOUR NAME' (with a placeholder 'Full name') and 'PHONE' (with a placeholder '10-digit number'), followed by a 'Publish post' button. The top right of the interface includes a user profile icon and two toggle buttons labeled 'Lost' and 'Found'.

Browse Items Module:

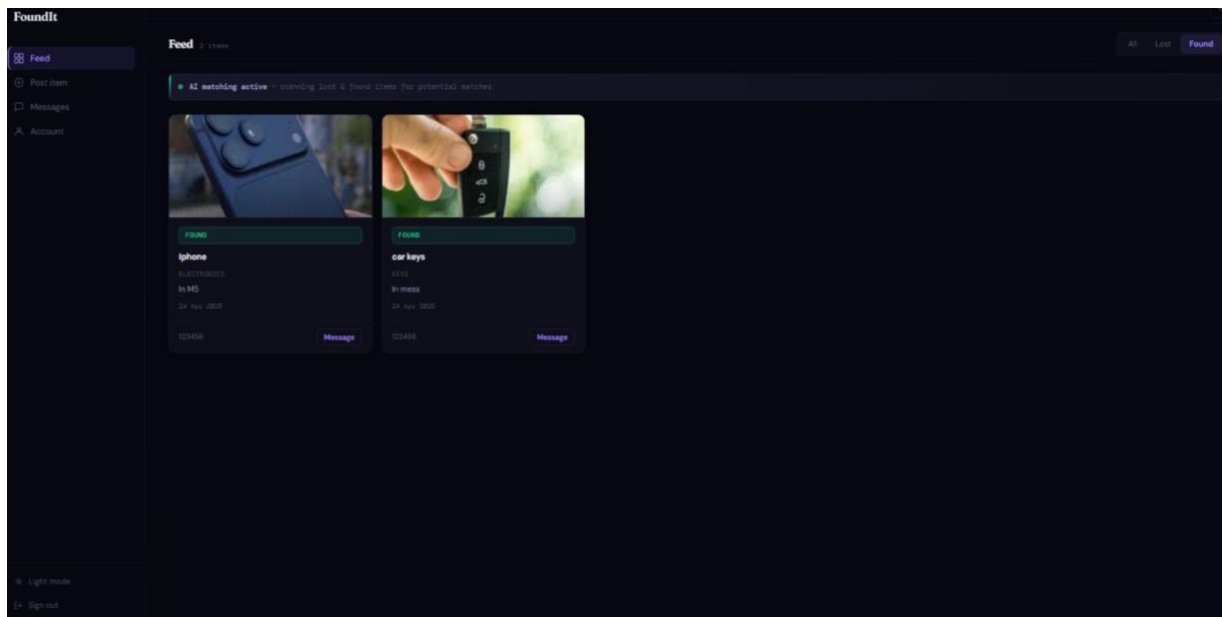
The Browse Found Items module allows users to view all items that have been reported as found on the platform. This feature is especially useful for users who have lost an item and are searching for it among the reported found items.

The module displays a list of found items along with key details such as item name, category, description, contact information, and images. Users can easily scroll through the listings and use filtering options to narrow down results based on specific categories, making the search process more efficient.

Each listing also includes an option such as **“Claim Now,”** which allows users to initiate a request if they believe the item belongs to them. The

request is then reviewed by the person who reported the item, ensuring a secure and verified process.

Overall, this module provides a structured and accessible way to browse found items, improving visibility and increasing the chances of successful item recovery.



Filtering & Categorization System:

The system includes a filtering and categorization feature to improve the efficiency of searching and browsing items. All reported items are organized into predefined categories such as electronics, bicycles, ID cards, umbrellas, and other common types, ensuring structured data management.

Users can apply multiple filters while searching or browsing items, allowing them to narrow down results based on category and relevance. This significantly reduces the time required to locate specific items and avoids the need to scroll through large amounts of unrelated data.

The categorization system also enhances the accuracy of search results and supports the overall organization of the platform. By providing a structured approach to data classification, this feature improves user experience and makes the system more efficient and easy to use.



AI Image Matching System:

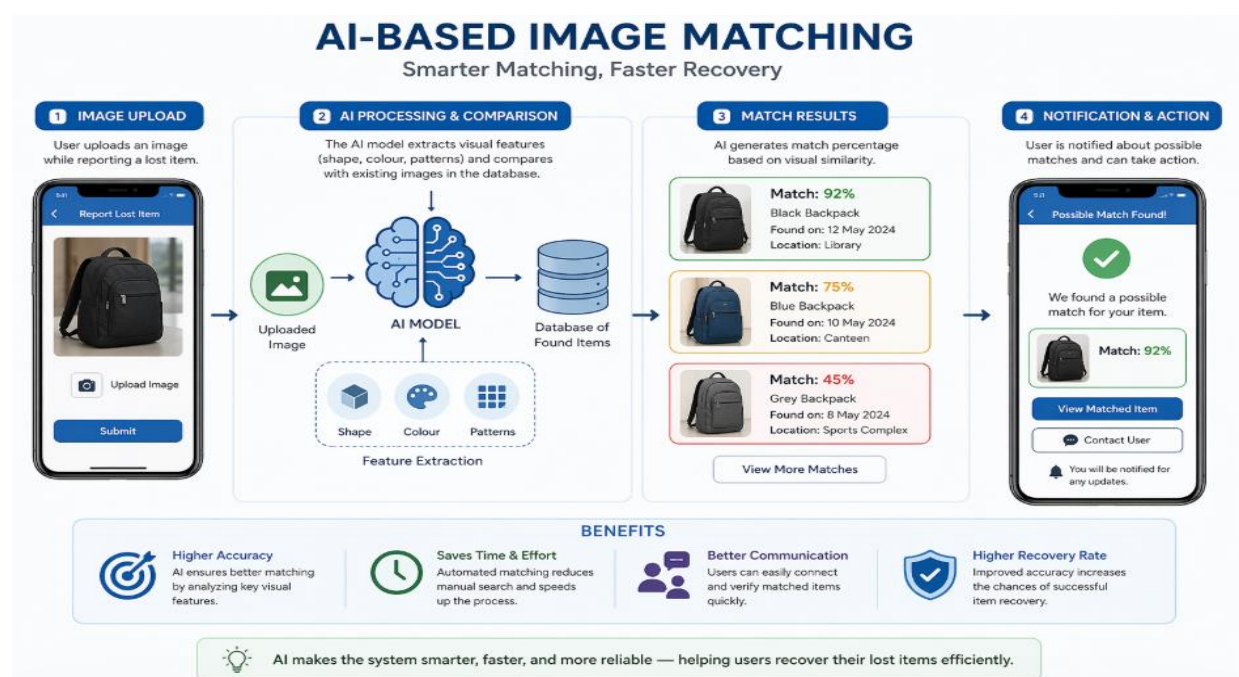
The system incorporates an AI-based image matching feature to improve the accuracy and efficiency of identifying lost and found items. This module helps users by automatically suggesting possible matches based on visual similarity, reducing manual searching efforts.

When an image is uploaded during item reporting, it is processed using a deep learning model based on **ResNet50**. The model extracts important visual features such as shape, colour, texture, and patterns from the image. These extracted features are then compared with images stored in

the database using **Cosine Similarity** to calculate how closely two items match.

If a potential match is found, the system notifies the user and provides options to view the matched item or contact the respective user. This enables faster verification and better communication between users.

Overall, this feature makes the system more intelligent and effective by improving matching accuracy and increasing the chances of successful item recovery.



Notification & Alert System:

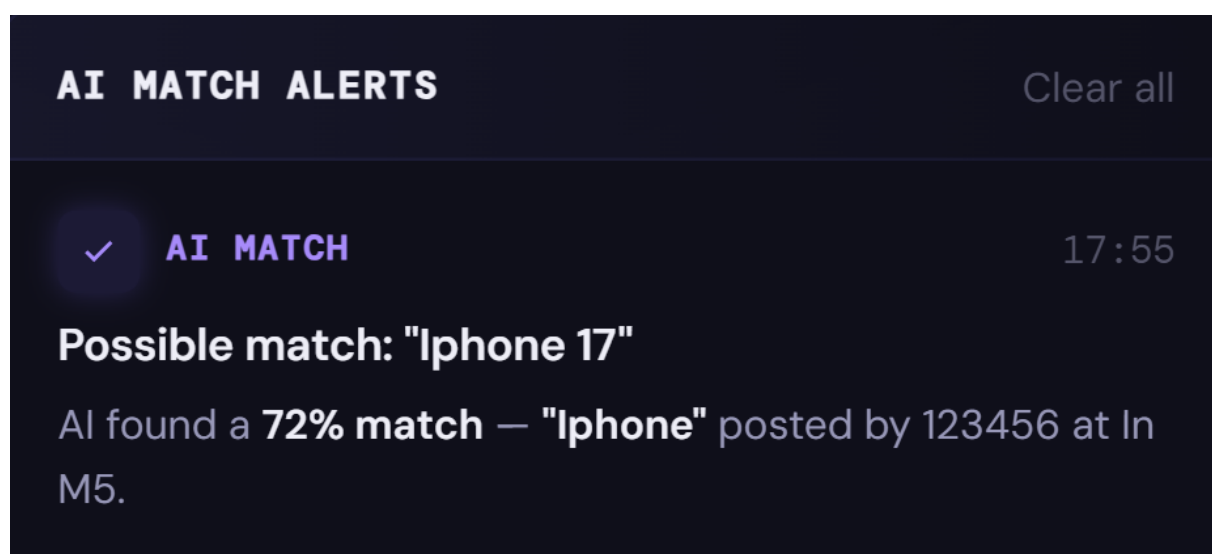
The system includes a notification and alert mechanism to keep users informed about important updates and activities related to their reported items. This feature ensures timely communication and enhances user engagement.

When a potential match is identified through the AI-based image matching system, the user is notified with details such as the match percentage and a link to view the item. Additionally, users receive alerts when someone

interacts with their listing, such as submitting a claim or reporting a found match.

These notifications help users take quick action, such as verifying items or contacting other users, thereby improving the chances of successful recovery. The alert system ensures that users stay updated without the need to manually check the platform frequently.

Overall, the notification system enhances responsiveness, improves communication, and makes the platform more efficient and user-friendly.



Claim & Approval Process:

The system includes a structured claim and approval process to ensure that lost items are returned to their rightful owners in a secure and reliable manner. This process helps prevent false claims and maintains trust among users.

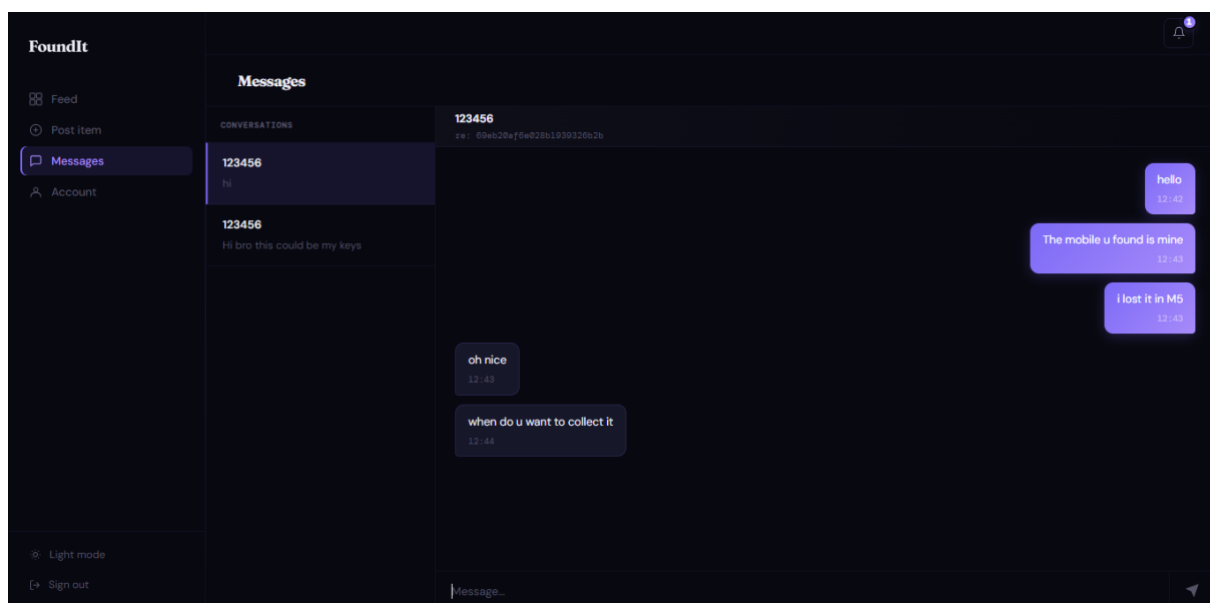
When a user finds their item in the found items section, they can select the **Claim Now** option. A form is displayed where the user provides contact details and a brief description to verify ownership of the item. The claim request is then sent to the user who reported the found item.

The reporting user can review the request and decide whether to approve or reject it based on the information provided. If approved, both users can communicate through the inbuilt messaging system to discuss item details, meeting location, and handover arrangements safely.

Users can also directly send messages regarding any listed item to ask questions or share additional information before making a claim. This improves communication and helps confirm ownership more effectively.

Once the claim is approved and the item is handed over successfully, the item listing is removed from the platform to avoid duplicate claims.

Overall, this process ensures secure communication, ownership verification, and an efficient method for returning lost items to their rightful owners.



After the item has been successfully handed over, the user can click the **Returned** button. This updates the item status in the system and removes it from the active feed, ensuring that only available listings are displayed to users.



Database Design (MongoDB):

The system uses **MongoDB**, a NoSQL database, to efficiently store and manage all application data. MongoDB is chosen for its flexibility, scalability, and ability to handle unstructured data such as images and dynamic item details.

The database is organized into different collections, primarily including **users**, **lost items**, **found items**, and **claims**. Each collection stores relevant information such as user credentials, item details (name, category, description), uploaded images, and contact information. This structured organization allows efficient data storage and retrieval.

MongoDB's document-based model enables easy modification and expansion of data fields without affecting existing records, making the

system adaptable to future changes. It also supports fast querying, which improves the performance of search and filtering operations.

Overall, the database design ensures efficient data management, quick access to information, and scalability, making it suitable for handling large volumes of data in the system.



Karma Points & Incentive System:

The system includes a karma points and incentive mechanism to encourage users to actively participate in reporting found items and helping others recover their belongings.

Users are awarded karma points whenever they report a found item or assist in successfully returning an item to its rightful owner. These points reflect the user's helpfulness and contribution to the campus community.

From time to time, the college administration can review the accumulated points and reward top contributors with appreciation certificates, small

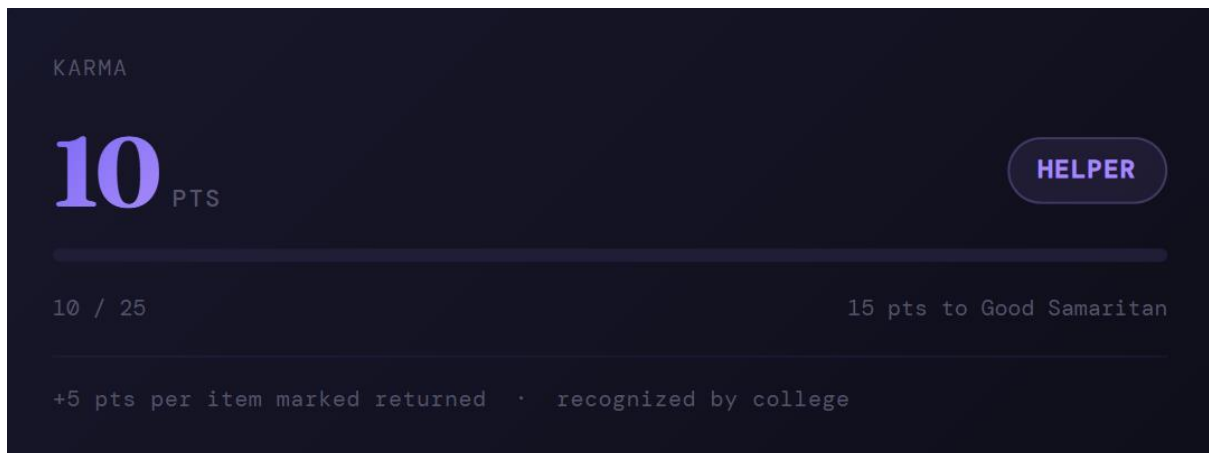
prizes, or other incentives. This motivates students to remain active on the platform and support one another.

The incentive system increases user participation, improves the number of found item reports, and promotes honesty, cooperation, and social responsibility.

The karma points system also includes different achievement levels based on the total points earned by a user. Users begin as **Newcomer**, then progress to **Helper**, **Good Samaritan**, **Campus Guardian**, and finally **Campus Hero** as they gain more points through active participation. These levels recognize helpful users, encourage continued contribution, and create a rewarding experience within the platform.

Overall, the karma points feature helps build a more connected, supportive, and responsible campus community.





Results & Discussion:

The developed system was tested to evaluate its performance, usability, and effectiveness in managing lost and found items. The results show that the platform successfully provides a structured and organized approach compared to traditional methods. Users were able to easily report items, search through categorized listings, and interact with others through a streamlined interface.

The implementation of features such as category-based filtering and structured data storage significantly reduced the time required to locate relevant items. Additionally, the AI-based image matching system assisted

users by suggesting potential matches, improving the accuracy and efficiency of item identification.

User interaction features like the claim and approval process ensured secure communication and helped verify ownership, reducing the chances of false claims. The notification system further enhanced responsiveness by keeping users informed about updates and potential matches.

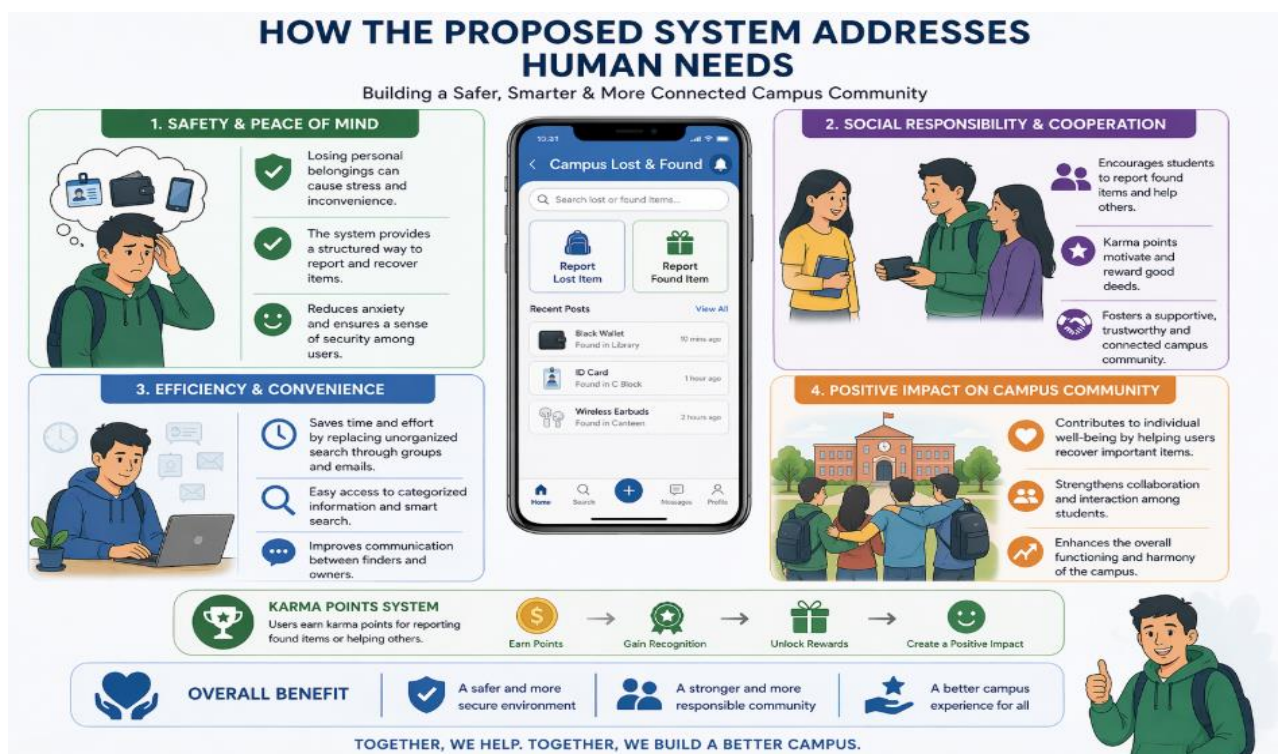
Overall, the system demonstrated improved efficiency, better user experience, and higher chances of successful item recovery. The results validate that a centralized and technology-driven approach is more effective than existing unstructured methods.

Human Needs & Social Impact:

The proposed system addresses important human needs related to safety, convenience, and social cooperation within a campus environment. Losing personal belongings such as ID cards, wallets, or electronic devices can cause stress and inconvenience. By providing a structured platform to report and recover items, the system helps reduce anxiety and ensures a sense of security among users.

The platform also promotes social responsibility and cooperation among students. Features like reporting found items and the karma points system encourage individuals to help others, fostering a supportive and connected campus community. This strengthens trust and interaction among users.

In addition, the system improves efficiency by saving time and effort required to search for lost items through unorganized channels. It enhances accessibility to information and ensures better communication between users. Overall, the project contributes positively to both individual well-being and the collective functioning of the campus community.



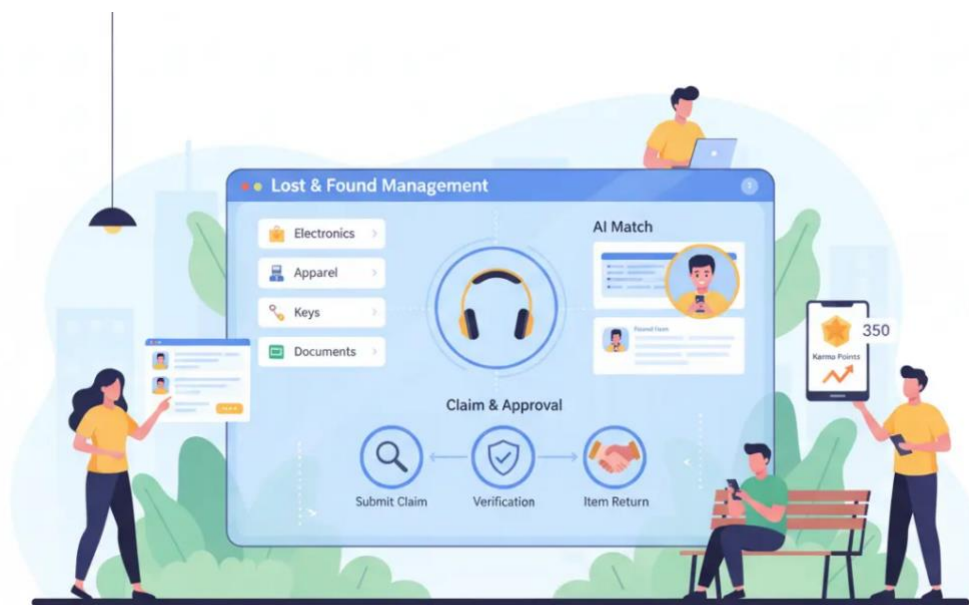
Advantages of the System:

The system provides a centralized platform for managing lost and found items, eliminating the need for scattered and unorganized communication channels such as messaging groups and emails. This improves accessibility and ensures that all information is available in one place.

It enhances search efficiency through category-based filtering and structured listings, allowing users to quickly find relevant items without going through unnecessary data. The user-friendly interface further simplifies navigation and improves overall usability.

The integration of AI-based image matching increases the accuracy of identifying items and reduces manual effort. Additionally, the claim and approval process ensures secure interaction and helps verify ownership, minimizing false claims.

The system also promotes user participation through the karma points mechanism, encouraging individuals to report found items. Overall, it improves efficiency, reliability, and the chances of successful item recovery.



Limitations of the System:

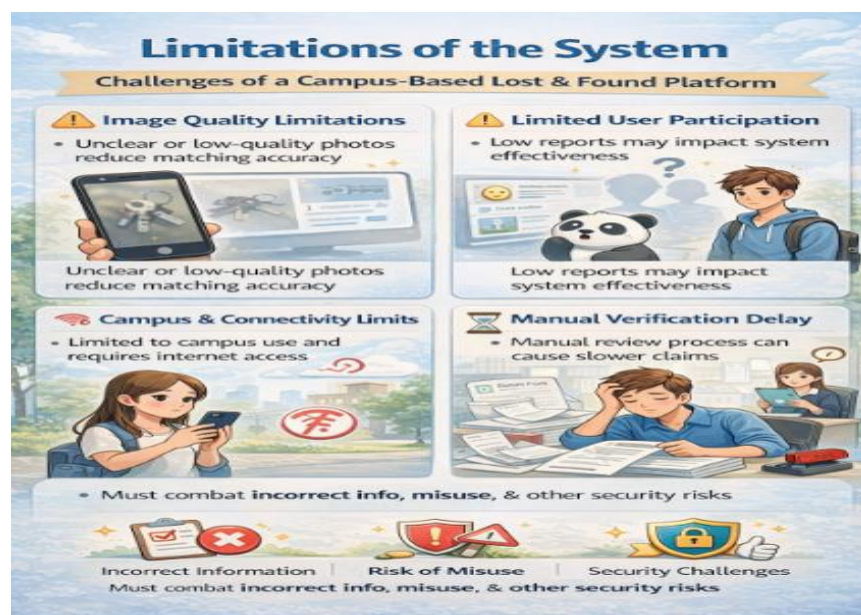
Despite its advantages, the system has certain limitations. The accuracy of the AI-based image matching depends on the quality of uploaded images; unclear or low-quality images may reduce matching effectiveness.

Additionally, the system relies on user participation, and if users do not actively report lost or found items, the overall efficiency of the platform may decrease.

The platform is currently limited to a specific campus environment, which restricts its usability on a larger scale. It also requires internet connectivity, making it less accessible in situations with poor network availability. Furthermore, there is a possibility of incorrect or incomplete information being entered by users, which may affect the accuracy of listings.

Another limitation is the dependency on manual verification in the claim and approval process, which may sometimes lead to delays. While the system includes security measures, it cannot completely eliminate the risk of false claims or misuse.

Overall, these limitations highlight areas for improvement and provide opportunities for further enhancement of the system.



Future Scope & Scalability:

The system has significant potential for future enhancements and expansion beyond its current scope. It can be scaled to support multiple

institutions, enabling inter-college connectivity and creating a larger network for lost and found item management.

The platform can be extended into a mobile application for Android and iOS, allowing users to receive real-time notifications and access the system more conveniently. Further improvements can be made to the AI module by incorporating advanced image recognition techniques to increase matching accuracy.

Integration with institutional systems such as student databases or security departments can enhance verification and improve reliability. Additional features like real-time chat, location tagging, and multilingual support can further improve user experience.

Overall, the system is designed to be scalable and adaptable, making it suitable for deployment in larger environments such as universities, public spaces, and commercial areas in the future.



Conclusion:

The Found-It project provides an effective and organized solution for managing lost and found items within the IIT Ropar campus. It replaces scattered communication methods with a centralized web-based platform that allows users to report, search, and recover items easily.

The inclusion of category-based filtering, secure user authentication, messaging features, and AI-based image matching improves the speed, accuracy, and convenience of finding lost items. The claim and approval process ensures proper verification before handover, making the system more secure and reliable.

Overall, the platform improves coordination among users, reduces the chances of information being missed, and increases the possibility of recovering lost belongings. It successfully addresses an important real-life campus need through the use of modern technology.

Website URL: <https://founditfrontend-ibx0.onrender.com>